History has a dreadful habit of repeating itself in Israel. On October 6, 1973, basking in the phenomenal success of the 1967 Six-Day War, Israel was caught napping when Egypt and Syria launched attacks against it on Yom Kippur, one of the holiest days for Jews. Though Israel beat back the military offensive and recovered territory, the then prime minister, Golda Meir, paid the price for the massive intelligence failure when her party was reduced to a minority in parliamentary elections the next year.

Now, exactly 50 years later, just as Israel was about to secure a breakthrough agreement with Saudi Arabia as a follow-up to the signing of the Abraham Accords in 2020 with four other Arab states, it was caught by surprise by a major terror attack from Hamas, the militant nationalist group that controls the Palestinian territory of Gaza, on October 7. Hamas fired more than 5,000 missiles raining death and destruction on major Israeli population centres, accompanied by land and sea offensives. Unprecedented in scale, the Hamas attack left more than 1,200 Israelis, mainly civilians, dead, and another 2,700 wounded.

Israeli prime minister Benjamin Netanyahu declared that his country was at war even as the Israel Defense Forces (IDF) launched major airstrikes, putatively against numerous targets in Hamas, leaving the densely-populated Gaza Strip devastated. Over 1,100 people were killed and another 5,000-plus injured, including many civilians, in just the first four days of the IDF's counterstrikes. The destruction of more than 500 residential buildings left an estimated 250,000 homeless. Simultaneously, Israel announced a fuel, food and electricity blockade against Gaza. Though Israeli citizens will certainly take Netanyahu to task for the massive intelligence failure once the Gaza offensive is over, the Opposition parties have for the moment agreed to be part of a national unity government to punish Hamas.

The major western nations have backed Israel, with US president Joe Biden assuring Tel Aviv with the words, "The US has your back." Arab and Islamic governments have been more varied in their response so far. The UAE condemned the Hamas attack, but rushed $20 mil-

ISRAEL-PALESTINE
ANVIL OF HOSTILITY

THE ENMITY BETWEEN ISRAEL AND THE PALESTINIANS IS OVER 75 YEARS OLD, AND HAS SEEN MULTIPLE CYCLES OF VIOLENCE, REPRISALS, ATTEMPTS AT PEACE, OPEN CONFLICT–ALL BASED ON EQUALLY EXCLUSIVE CLAIMS TO TRACTS OF LAND AS THEIR OWN

1947
End of British mandate of Palestine. UN Resolution 181 calls for partition of Palestine into Jewish and Arab states. Arabs reject it, violence grows

1948
Israel declares **independence**. Victorious in the first Arab-Israeli war, grabs land excluding Gaza Strip, West Bank. An estimated 700,000 Palestinians are displaced. They call it the 'Nakba' (catastrophe)


INDIA PICTURE

JUNE 1967
Six-Day War Israeli victory over Egypt, Syria, Jordan; occupation of Gaza Strip, Sinai, West Bank, Golan Heights and East Jerusalem


AP